The Journal of Open Source Software

Blobmodel: A Python package for generating superpositions of pulses in one and two dimensions

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DOI: 10.xxxxxx/draft

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Submitted: 14 February 2025
Published: unpublished

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Summary

`blobmodel` is a Python library for generating synthetic data that mimics the behavior of moving pulses in a turbulent environment. It creates controlled datasets where the true motion of each pulse is known, allowing researchers gain further understanding on the statistical outputs of such systems as well as to test and improve analysis and tracking algorithms. While originally developed for studying turbulence in fusion experiments, `blobmodel` can be applied to any field where turbulence leads to the generation of structures propagating in one or two dimensions. The software is open source, easy to use, and designed to support reproducible research.

Statement of need

Understanding and analyzing the motion of structures in turbulent systems is crucial in many areas of research, including plasma physics (D'Ippolito et al., 2011), fluid dynamics (Fiedler, 1988), and atmospheric science (Nosov et al., 2009).

More widely, the study of the statistical characteristics resulting from the superposition of uncorrelated propagating pulses is of importance in fields such as astrophysical plasmas (Veltri, 1999), detection rates of interplanetary dust (Kočiščák, S. et al., 2023), $1/f$ noise in self-organized critical systems (Bak et al., 1988), shot noise in electronics (Lowen & Teich, 1990)

In experimental studies, imaging diagnostics are often used to capture the evolution of these structures (Zweben et al., 2017), but extracting reliable velocity information from such data remains challenging (Offeddu et al., 2023). Many existing analysis methods rely on assumptions about the underlying dynamics and must be tested against known reference data to ensure accuracy.

Several stochastic models have been developed describing a superposition of uncorrelated structures arriving in time in zero spatial dimensions (Garcia et al., 2016); or propagating in one (Losada et al., 2023) or two (F. Militello et al., 2018) spatial dimensions. In the simplest cases, it is possible to derive analytical expressions for different statistical quantities such as probability density functions, autocorrelation functions, power spectral densities and spatial dependence of the mean or other higher-order moments (Garcia et al., 2016; Losada et al., 2023; F. Militello & Omotani, 2016). More general scenarios require numerical tools (Losada, Paikina, et al., 2024), and synthetic realizations of the model.

`blobmodel` addresses this need by providing a framework for generating synthetic datasets resulting from a superposition of uncorrelated pulses (Losada & Garcia, 2025; F. Militello et al., 2018):

$$\Phi(x,y,t) = \sum_{k=1}^{K} a_k \varphi\left(\frac{x - v_k(t-t_k)}{\ell_{x,k}}, \frac{(y-y_k) - w_k(t-t_k)}{\ell_{y,k}}\right),$$

where the pulse amplitudes a_k, velocity components v_k and w_k, arrival times t_k, arrival positions y_k and sizes $\ell_{x,k}$ and $\ell_{y,k}$ are random variables. Additionally, each pulse may be tilted an angle given by an additional random variable θ_k with respect to its centre.

The framework allows an explicit definition of all relevant process parameters, including:

- All pulse parameters if defined as degenerate random variables.
- All distribution functions of the pulse parameters otherwise.
- Optionally, a drainage term $\tau_{\parallel}$ that models an exponential decay in the pulse amplitude.
- Spatial and temporal resolution.
- Degree of pulse overlap.
- Signal length.

This allows researchers to systematically test and benchmark tracking algorithms and velocity estimation techniques in a controlled setting. Originally developed for studying turbulence-driven transport in fusion plasma experiments, blobmodel is applicable to any system where turbulence leads to the formation of moving structures in one or two-dimensional space. By offering an open-source and easily accessible tool, blobmodel supports the development and validation of analysis methods used in experimental and computational research.

For more details visit blobmodel's documentation.

The package has been used to generate synthetic data to study and compare the robustness of velocity estimation techniques on coarse-grained imaging data (Losada, Helgeland, et al., 2024).

Additionally, theoretically predicted radial profiles from stochastic modelling (Garcia et al., 2016; F. Militello & Omotani, 2016) agree with those obtained with `blobmodel`.

Implementation details

Since the simulation domain has finite spatial extent, pulses may originate or extend beyond its boundaries. If a pulse has a non-bound shape, such as a Gaussian, its tails can still contribute to the superposition inside the domain. However, in long simulations, most pulses will exist outside the domain for the majority of the time, making it computationally inefficient to account for all of them. To improve efficiency, a `speed_up` flag has been added to `Model.make_realization`. When enabled, the model ignores pulses whose contribution within the domain falls below a user-defined `error` threshold. This allows for significant computational savings while maintaining accuracy in the simulation.

Periodicity in the vertical direction is an optional feature. It is implemented by replicating each pulse at vertical positions $y_b \pm L_y$, where y_b is the pulse's original position and L_y is the vertical size of the simulation domain. This ensures that blobs crossing the upper or lower boundaries are correctly wrapped around, maintaining continuity in the periodic direction.

This package is fully compatible with `xarray` (Hoyer & Hamman, 2017), with all outputs provided as `xarray` datasets for easy handling and analysis.

Acknowledgements

This work was supported by the UiT Aurora Centre Program, UiT The Arctic University of Norway (2020).

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